

Has AI made students smarter, or just more dependent?

Where should educators draw the line?



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AI has undoubtedly expanded students' cognitive reach, enhancing access, accelerating ideation, and enabling rapid prototyping. However, the real question is not whether AI makes students smarter or more dependent, but how consciously it is embedded within pedagogy.

At the School of Arts and Design, Woxsen University, our Vision 2030 positions AI as collaborative intelligence — augmenting, not replacing, human creativity. We begin with hands-on skills — drawing, material exploration, and making — ensuring students first develop tactile understanding and originality. AI is then introduced as an enabler, not a shortcut.

The line must be drawn where dependency dilutes critical thinking and authorship. Our approach integrates AI within a framework of responsibility and reflection, shaping designers who not only use technology but question and humanise it.



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AI has not simply made students smarter or more dependent — it has done both, depending on how it's used. When used thoughtfully, AI deepens understanding by offering explanations, examples, and personalised feedback, helping students grasp difficult concepts faster. It acts like a tireless tutor, encouraging curiosity and independent learning.

However, overreliance weakens critical thinking. If students use AI to generate answers without reflection, they skip the mental effort needed to truly learn, becoming passive consumers rather than active thinkers. The real issue isn't AI itself, but how students are taught to use it.

When guided by strong educational practices emphasising reasoning, creativity, and ethics, AI can make students smarter. Without those safeguards, it risks creating dependence rather than genuine growth.



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Artificial Intelligence has not necessarily made students smarter — but it has made possibilities visible. It shows learners what can be done, shifting focus from doing everything manually to understanding what truly matters. AI responds to the quality of input it receives, so the real skill today is not just knowledge, but the ability to ask the right questions.

This places strong emphasis on communication and contextual understanding. Without clarity of thought, AI outputs can be inaccurate — making its use more challenging than helpful. A key concern is that students may bypass foundational understanding, losing the depth required to innovate and solve real-world problems.

In the future workplace, students will collaborate with AI. The balance lies in using it to enhance thinking, not replace it.



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Artificial intelligence has certainly changed how students learn, but it's a double-edged sword. On one hand, it helps students understand complex topics faster, offers personalized guidance, and saves time on repetitive tasks. On the other hand, it can make some students overly dependent, reducing their ability to think critically or solve problems on their own.

The real impact depends on how it is used. Educators should not ban AI, but guide students in using it responsibly—as a support tool, not a shortcut. The line should be drawn where learning stops and mere copying begins.

Encouraging curiosity, independent thinking, and ethical use of technology is key. In the end, AI should enhance a student's intelligence, not replace their effort or creativity.